

Reading People.

The **7-radicals cheat sheet** I used to hire engineers, designers, and marketers across 10+ products and 2 exits. How to spot who you're talking to in the **first 15 minutes** of an interview, what to trust them with, and **what will break them**.



Field notes, not science

This is a practitioner's pattern-matching system, not a validated psychometric instrument. It is based on the "7 radicals" model by Viktor Ponomarenko, a profiler who built it for reading people fast, in the field, without tests.

I started using it because startup hiring has a brutal constraint: you get 45 minutes with a stranger, no assessment budget, and the cost of a wrong hire at a 5-person company is existential. Résumés tell you what people did. They don't tell you **what kind of work this specific nervous system will do brilliantly and what will quietly destroy them**. That second question is what this system is for.

The model in one paragraph

A "radical" is a stable behavioral tendency that shows up in everything at once: speech, dress, gestures, what a person does under pressure. Nobody is one radical; everyone is a mix with one or two dominant. Your job in an interview is not to label a person, it's to **rank their top two radicals** and match the dominant one to the actual daily texture of the role: routine or chaos, people or systems, stage or shadow.

How to use it in a 45-minute interview

- **Minutes 0–5: the presentation layer.** Dress, posture, how they fill the room. The Performer is loudest here; the Guardian is nearly invisible. First impressions overweight radicals 01 and 06, so hold your conclusion.
- **Listen for speech markers over content.** Content is rehearsed; speech structure is not. Verbs and imperatives (02), systems and "always/everyone" (03), question cascades (05), "I" density (01), negative reframing (07).
- **Challenge one claim and watch the reaction.** The Crusader argues the system, the Enforcer bristles and defends territory, the Analyst reframes the question, the Empath softens, the Guardian retreats.
- **Rank top two, then check role fit** against the pages that follow. The combination pages matter more than single radicals: real people live in the combos.

Three hard rules. First: this is a lens for adapting your communication and deciding what to probe deeper, never the reason to hire or reject; decisions come from structured interviews and work samples. Second: observe behavior only, never screen by age, body, gender, or anything else you'd be ashamed to say out loud. Third: the model describes tendencies, not destiny; a strong senior person has usually built skills their radical doesn't predict.

What I dropped from the original methodology and you should too: body-type readings and age archetypes. They add discrimination risk and near-zero interview signal. Everything in this guide is observable behavior a candidate chooses: how they speak, dress, move, and react.

01 The Performer

HISTRIONIC RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Pleasure & attention

Core drive: **attention and recognition**. Life is a stage; the audience's reaction is the metric. Not a creator, an imitator, and often a brilliant one.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Talks about themselves relentlessly; four or five "I" per sentence, achievements front-loaded.
- Wins the first five minutes: instant charm, camera-ready poses, theatrical gestures.
- Eye-catching presentation: statement pieces, deliberate originality within fashion.
- Thoughts jump and overlap; the story is vivid but shallow on follow-up questions.
- Redefines weaknesses on the fly: "not fired, outgrew the role"; almost never self-critical.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Public recognition of wins: shout-outs, titles, awards, a visible stage.
- Genuine compliments and attention; they will work hard for an audience.
- Short, varied assignments with a demo at the end.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- Being the face: pitches, demos, PR, brand, evangelism.
- B2B sales and top-management presence; first impressions at scale.
- Content front-man, model behavior for the audience.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Routine work needing persistence, attention, and follow-through.
- Deep, lonely problem-solving marathons; they'll fake progress before admitting boredom.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Compete with them for attention.
- Ignore them; withdrawal of attention reads as punishment.

HIRING VERDICT Hire for the first impression your company makes, never for the last mile. Trust the demo, independently verify the delivery.

02 The Enforcer

EPILEPTOID RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Anger & irritation

Core drive: **order and control of their territory**. Everything and everyone classified, in its place, with clear rules and known resources.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Short, action-directed sentences packed with verbs and imperatives: must, need, do. Almost no adjectives.
- Meticulous listing of details, procedures, steps; repeats to make sure you got it.
- Functional, orderly presentation: everything neat, nothing decorative, short practical haircut.
- Restrained face, slow controlled movements; may narrow their eyes sizing you up.
- Maximally correct with people above them, harsh with people below. Watch how they mention juniors and waiters.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- Precision routine: QA, ops, logistics, compliance, finance ops, security.
- Process, discipline, deadlines; craft mastery of any kind.
- Making chaos boringly reliable.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Mentoring and people development: a drill sergeant, not a coach.
- Fuzzy 0→1 exploration with no rules to enforce.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Show the situation is under control, yours or theirs; define their territory explicitly.
- Respect their zone of competence; keep agreements and deadlines to the letter.
- Be predictable. Push back on their power grabs early or accept full submission later.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Be a source of chaos; miss deadlines; break agreed process.
- Long abstract talk about futures and philosophy.

HIRING VERDICT The person who makes your operations dull in the best sense. Give them territory and rules, not visions, and never renegotiate casually.

03 The Crusader

PARANOIAC RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Contempt for obstacles

Core drive: **one large-scale goal**. Boredom is their mild contempt for anything that isn't the mission. The founder's radical.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Generalizes and systematizes: always, everyone, in general, "this leads to", "the more X, the more Y".
- Simple examples and metaphors chosen to be maximally understood; sharp, pragmatic speech.
- Challenges your reasoning back: "what are you basing that on?", "how did you conclude that?"
- Physically closes distance to be understood; rhythmic, directing gestures.
- Classic, no-frills presentation; sometimes affiliation marks: logos, movement symbols.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- Anything with a concrete result at the end; strategy carried to execution.
- Leadership at any level; analysis, systems thinking.
- Long games nobody else has the stamina for.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Work requiring sustained attention to one individual human: care, coaching, HR empathy work.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Align with their goal or step out of the way; join the mission rather than assign tasks.
- Give ownership of outcomes, not lists of activities.
- If you must oppose them, do it their way: recruit allies, appeal to the public, build a system.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Try to re-convince them head-on; you'll lose the frame.
- Flatter them; they already agree with the compliment.
- Leave them idle.

HIRING VERDICT

Your future co-founder or department head. One test decides everything: is their goal and your company's goal the same goal? If not, they will build theirs inside yours.

04 The Empath

EMOTIVE RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Joy & calm

Core drive: **harmony between people**. High sensitivity to weak signals; they read a room the way dashboards never will.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Smooth, melodic, quiet speech; naturally literate, correctly pronounced.
- Dense with positive and considerate phrasing: "excuse me", "would you be so kind".
- Soft, comfortable presentation: no sharp angles, knitwear over armor, harmony over statement.
- Restrained but precise, expressive gestures; poses comfortable for everyone in the room.
- Detects insincerity instantly; watch them cool a few degrees when someone performs friendliness.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Sincerity only; they'll forgive hard truths sooner than fake warmth.
- Show the human purpose of the work; keep the culture tactful.
- Protect from overload and ragged rhythm; build in recovery time.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- People work: support, customer success, HR, community.
- Editing, design harmony, service, hospitality.
- Being the team's emotional early-warning system.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Hardball: firing, collections, tough negotiations, enforcement, control.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Fake friendliness or interest; the lie lands louder than the words.
- Rudeness, harsh public criticism, vulgarity.
- Grind them with no time to think or rest.

HIRING VERDICT

Hire one before you think you need them. They hear the team and the customer weeks before your metrics do, and they'll tell you if you've built a culture where telling you is safe.

05 The Analyst

SCHIZOID RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Interest

Core drive: **the process of understanding itself**. No external goal; taking reality apart to the atoms is the point. The R&D radical.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Question cascades: what, why, how, what if. "Let's look at it differently."
- Precise disagreement: "not always", "not quite", "allow me to disagree", then a counter-model.
- "There are many options" is a native sentence; hidden meaning is a hobby.
- Eclectic, convention-indifferent presentation; mismatched pieces, a bag full of who-knows-what.
- Angular, unchoreographed movements; odd postures; expressions detached from the conversation.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Accept the oddness wholesale; judge output, not process or appearance.
- Small, stable circle of contacts; don't rotate their environment.
- Don't force your way into their inner world; show acceptance and they'll open the door themselves.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- R&D, programming, architecture, research, invention.
- Problems with no known playbook.
- Philosophy-grade abstraction applied to engineering.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Template-regulated, checklist-driven work.
- Front-of-house anything; forced constant novelty of faces.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Mock the quirks or dismiss their worldview.
- Dominate, humiliate, or apply hard public criticism.
- Rotate people around them constantly.

HIRING VERDICT Your unfair technical advantage, if and only if you insulate them from process noise and people churn. The interview will undersell them; the work sample won't.

06 The Energizer

HYPERTHYMIC RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Surprise & play

Core drive: **contact, novelty, events**. The network node: their goal is people in motion, and they are the motion.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Fast, loud speech; fountains of ideas; tirades that outrun the question.
- Everything at speed: walks fast, talks fast, decides fast.
- Face jumps from emotion to emotion; the resting state is joy.
- Greets everyone, touches shoulders, makes the room feel like their party.
- Casual weekend-grade presentation, cheerfully half-done: something unbuttoned, something forgotten.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- Connecting people and groups: bizdev, partnerships, events.
- Community, field sales, anything requiring hundreds of first contacts.
- Being the reason strangers become a room.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Monotony, solitary deep work.
- Anything where the value is in finishing, not starting.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Give motion, people, and variety; point the energy at doors you need opened.
- Apply calm stubbornness to keep meetings on the rails.
- Don't try to hold them close; you can't, and trying breeds resentment.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Isolation and silence.
- Repetitive routine with no new faces.

HIRING VERDICT You're renting their network and momentum. Pair every Energizer with an Enforcer who closes what they open, and count closed deals, not opened doors.

07 The Guardian

ANXIOUS RADICAL

BASE EMOTION

Fear

Core drive: **safety and preservation of the known**. Novelty is a cost, responsibility is a threat, the familiar is the reward.

SPOT THEM IN AN INTERVIEW

- Redefines events into negatives: "not fun, reckless"; "not rainy, pre-storm".
- Verbal distancing from anything new or unknown.
- Quiet monotone, few words; sits on the edge of the chair; shades of worry cross the face.
- Blends into the background: dark tones, no ornament, the same reliable outfit every day.
- Needs a long warm-up before you see anything real; the first interview underrates them badly.

MANAGE & MOTIVATE

- Predictability above all: rules agreed once and never changed suddenly.
- Moral and informational support; a gentle, empathic tone.
- Train slowly and step by step; once learned, it's learned forever.

WHERE THEY EXCEL

- Reliable execution of well-learned routine; meticulous checking, monitoring.
- Long-term stable roles; loyalty champions.
- Exacting checklist work where deviation is the enemy.

DON'T ASSIGN

- Public anything; fast autonomous decisions; risk-taking.
- Frequently changing duties.

NEVER DO THIS TO THEM

- Surprise them or force snap decisions.
- Revoke prior agreements or change the rules mid-game.
- Leave them alone with unfolding uncertainty.

HIRING VERDICT Slowest to onboard, last to leave. In a startup, hire only into a stable, well-fenced lane, and be honest with yourself about how few of those a startup has.

Combinations: how actual people arrive

Nobody walks in as a pure radical. The dominant radical sets the goal; the second supplies the means. Order matters: Performer-Enforcer and Enforcer-Performer are different people.

Performer + Enforcer

HARD-CLOSING SALES

Professional, insistent image-building backed by force. Illusions of quality you can't wave away, because their author will also enforce the deal. Relentless in pursuit; audit what was actually promised to the client.

Performer + Empath

BRAND FACE / CLIENT LEAD

The most winning presence in the book: taste, tact, and charm with nothing "too much". Self-presentation as an art form. Put them in front of your most valuable relationships.

Crusader + Energizer

THE FOUNDER COCKTAIL

A mountain range of plans plus the unstoppable urge to realize them, recruiting everyone in reach and expecting only success. If you're hiring this person, understand you're hiring a future founder; give them a company-sized goal or lose them to their own.

Crusader + Guardian

RISK-AWARE OPERATOR

Purposeful building with one eye permanently on the downside. Restrained social activity, persistence in defending the right to keep things stable. Excellent second-in-command for a founder who runs hot.

Analyst + Enforcer

STAFF ENGINEER GOLD

A schizoid goal (endless creative search) achieved by epileptoid means: detailed craftsmanship, classification, systematization, and real aggression toward sloppy reasoning. The rare senior IC who both invents and finishes.

Enforcer + Analyst

OPS WITH A TWIST

The mirror image: an ordered, controlled life achieved by unconventional routes. Sometimes the shortcut is genius, sometimes a dead end; either way they out-maneuver competitors who only know the manual.

Analyst + Empath

PRODUCT-MINDED ENGINEER

The search for new forms and meanings, conducted with genuine care for people. Research that refuses to hurt anyone on the way. UX research, product engineering, careful science.

Empath + Energizer

COMMUNITY / CS

Warm-hearted people who love a crowd: harmonizing relations, building an atmosphere where everyone cooperates, endlessly widening the circle. They notice the one quiet person at the party and go sit with them. Community and customer success royalty.

Energizer + Crusader

PARTNERSHIPS / BD

Connections acquiring social purpose: "he doesn't need money, he needs contacts." Networking elevated to a mission. Point them at an ecosystem you need to be inside of by next quarter.

Guardian + Performer

PROMOTION TRAP

A craving for recognition capped by fear of responsibility. Wants the title, avoids the ownership; hides in comforting illusions when pressed. Be careful: promoting them to a visible role is a favor to no one, least of all them.

Energizer + Guardian

GREAT SECOND, NEVER FIRST

Sociable, easy-going, happily joins any adventure, and never once initiates one. Plenty of these people exist and they're pleasant to work with; just don't hand them the wheel and expect a destination.

Three team-design rules that fall out of the combos

- **Openers need closers.** Every Energizer and Performer on the team needs a paired Enforcer within one hop, or opened doors quietly swing shut.
- **Protect your Analysts with Enforcers, not with process.** Process written by an Enforcer shields the Analyst from noise; process imposed on the Analyst is noise.
- **One Crusader per goal.** Two Crusaders with different goals in one small company is not diversity, it's a fork waiting to happen. Align the goals or split the domains.

Role-fit matrix for a small team

The dominant radical to look for per role, and the one that will suffer or make you suffer. A strong second radical from the "look for" column beats a pure dominant.

ROLE	LOOK FOR	BE CAREFUL WITH
Outbound sales	Performer + Enforcer, Energizer	Guardian, Analyst
Customer support / success	Empath; Guardian for process depth	Performer
QA / compliance / ops	Enforcer, Guardian	Energizer, Performer
Hard engineering / R&D	Analyst; Analyst + Enforcer for seniors	Performer
Product / GTM leadership	Crusader; Crusader + Energizer	Guardian-dominant
Community / events / BD	Energizer + Empath	Analyst, Guardian
Back office / EA	Enforcer, Guardian	Energizer
Brand / PR / demos	Performer + Empath	Analyst, Guardian
Data / finance analysis	Analyst, Enforcer; Crusader for systems	Energizer
People / HR	Empath + Enforcer (care + fairness)	Pure Crusader

Interview red flags by radical, one each

- **Performer:** the story gets better every time they retell it in the same interview.
- **Enforcer:** contempt leaking when they describe former colleagues below them.
- **Crusader:** their goal survives every question, and your company appears in none of the answers.
- **Empath:** agrees with everything; you've learned nothing they actually think.
- **Analyst:** refuses the simple version of any answer, even when asked twice.
- **Energizer:** can't name one thing they finished alone, start to end.
- **Guardian:** every job change in their history was someone else's decision.

Final reminder: rank, don't label. Use this to decide what to probe and how to talk, then let structured questions and work samples make the decision. The system's real payoff isn't screening candidates, it's not breaking the good ones after you hire them.

Use this guide with an LLM

The fastest way to internalize the system, especially for your first ten or twenty interviews: don't hold the terminology in your head. Feed this PDF to an LLM and let it hold the framework while you hold the conversation.

COMPANION MODE: ANALYZING A SPECIFIC PERSON

After an interview, upload this guide to Claude or any capable model, then describe what you actually observed: how the person spoke, dressed, moved, reacted to challenge. The model maps your raw observations to the radicals, so you never get lost between "was that Enforcer or Crusader?" while the impression is still fresh.

I've attached a field guide to the 7-radicals model. Here are my raw notes from a 45-minute interview: [what they said, how they said it, presentation, reaction to being challenged]. Rank the candidate's top-2 radicals with evidence from my notes, flag what contradicts the ranking, and suggest what to probe in round two.

Ask for evidence and contradictions, not just a label: the disagreements between the model's reading and your gut are exactly the spots worth a second interview question.

THE SCREENING LIFEHACK THAT PRODUCED MY BEST HIRES

Reverse the usual order. Most founders read résumés first and think about fit later. Do the opposite:

- **1. Define the target profile before opening a single résumé.** Use the role-fit matrix: dominant radical, useful second, the one to be careful with. Write it down as a short spec.
- **2. Run incoming résumés through an LLM against that profile** as the initial screen. Give it this guide plus your spec. Word choice, self-description patterns, and the shape of a career leak radical signals even in edited text: an Enforcer's résumé lists procedures, a Performer's lists spotlight moments, a Crusader's reads as one mission in several acts.
- **3. The shortlist goes to human interviews**, where live speech gives you the real signal and this guide's interview pages take over.

This ordering is dramatically faster than manual first-pass screening, and it's how I made my best hires: the interviews start pre-focused on the two or three things worth probing instead of starting from zero.

Guardrails. LLM screening is a first pass, never a verdict: a human reviews every rejection. Résumés systematically understate Analysts and Guardians, whose signal lives in speech, not in polished text, so keep the bar for "no" high at this stage. And strip names and personal identifiers before feeding candidate documents to any third-party model.

TWO EXITS LATER

I write a weekly memo on building companies: **real metrics, real decisions, real dead ends.**

Breakdowns of \$1B+ private companies, the numbers behind my own products (two of them sold, more of them killed), and the filter I use to choose what to build next. From a founder who ships production code himself.

twoexitslater.com

Aleksei Balchunas · repeat founder, 2 exits (\$3.1M to Yandex) · 10+ consumer products · This guide is a practitioner's field notes based on V. Ponomarenko's 7-radicals model. Share it freely with a founder who's hiring.